

A case that matters

Agent 001 does a case study

I have long held the belief that the world population is divided into two kinds of people—those who live in a 64-bit colour world of deep purples and metallic blues, and those who live in shades of beige. And since I have long lived in the funky town of motherboards and graphics cards, why should my world be beige?

Thus started my hunt for a new PC cabinet that matched my style, but still fitted the state of my wallet—I would have to cap my purchase at Rs 2,000. And so off to our favourite haunt, Lamington Road.

At the first shop, the vendor showed me some cabinets ranging between Rs 850 and Rs 1,300. Even though he insisted that these models dominated the market, they didn't gel with me. Since my desk is home to every PC peripheral, I wanted a cabinet with all the razzmatazz—3.5-inch drive open bays (for floppy or Zip drives) and closed bays (for hard drives); 5.25-inch bays for CD-ROM and DVD-ROM drives; and plenty of room for additional cooling fans.

The shopkeeper showed me an ibox (the latest entrant and on the heavier side at 8 kg in this range), and cabinets from Kobian, Intex and Odyssey. He also showed me models from Mercury, another prominent brand that offers a wide range with features such as CD racks, USB ports, and blue florescent lights on the front when a PC is switched on. Intex is also a major player, but is popular mostly with assemblers—SI Odyssey and Kobian are more popular with users.

Keen to explore further, I decided to do some window-shopping and sauntered into a shop, which I felt had what I wanted. After listening to my wish-list, the shopkeeper told me that the power capacity (SMPS) of the cabinet should also be an important consideration. An SMPS of less than 250 watts should be avoided. You should ideally look for power supplies that are Intel or AMD certified. And the SMPS

should have support for an extra connector in case you're opting for a P4. He also cautioned me to not plug in things with high wattage requirements, such as electric heaters, into the same circuit as the computer.

This vendor also cautioned me that many manufactures choose thinner materials to construct their cases, thus reducing price but also compromising on the quality. According to him, I'd be better off with a fibre cabinet costing up to Rs 2,000. A decent buy would be ideally with a 250+ watts SMPS with at least three 5.25-inch bays keeping in mind the expansion, that is, one for a CD-ROM drive, one for CD-Writer plus a shelf for keeping CDs.

He educated me on some snazzy features in the chassis. Many cases now come with pre-cut 80 mm holes for 80 mm fans that mount onto the side panel of the case. Front-mounted USB and FireWire ports are now all the rage. You will have to make sure that your motherboard

supports the correct connection to the connection on the case. Removable drive cages are a requirement for most high-end cases. These drive cages come in all shapes and sizes, and now many of them offer an 80 mm fan that can be put directly in front of your hard drive in order to achieve good air flow.

So as you see, there's a lot more to this case. With case modding catching on, case manufactures should offer much better with time. Many companies now offer custom fan grills, back lights, plexiglass side panels and fan buses. But in India, only the experienced users ask for it.

I had enough of window shopping. Of all the cabinets, the one that caught my eye was the Performance Plus 660 AMG from Antec. A rugged 10-kg piece, it has three 5.25-inch and five 3.5-inch bays (two convertible). On the front bezel is a small



- Look for the number of external and internal drive bays.
- If you're not a power user, opt for a slimmer case such as the mini tower or the slimline case, which is large enough to house your components, and yet takes up less room. A mid-tower ATX case will give you the right balance between a roomy case for future upgrades and a space saver.
- Ensure that your motherboard fits into the computer case. The standard motherboard form factor today is ATX or MicroATX. Also check the length of your existing PCI and AGP cards and whether they fit your cabinet choice.
- Good case design also includes spaces for fans.
- Check for the presence of front mounted ports. Is the cabinet easy to work with or will it have to be completely disassembled to get to certain parts of the computer? The in-thing in this area is screwless cabinets with a security lock.

plastic spring-loaded flap to give access to two USB and one FireWire connection. The internal wiring quality is excellent with the motherboard power supply connector wire wrapped in nylon net. Besides, it has seven expansion slots, a 3003 W power supply and a washable air filter. It was all that I wanted. Ah! But then he told me the price—Rs 7,650.

I finally settled for the Odyssey ATX-403A—a metallic silver beauty with a neon light and a provision for a CD rack. It has four 5.25-inch bays and neat looks to support my latest list of peripherals. And yes, it has additional hard disk slots so I can ramp up on space if my movie files grow out of hand. Besides, it's screwless and comes with a nifty security lock. The flipside is that since every thing in the case is riveted, it's difficult to add or remove drives. The power supply connector of the motherboard slightly obstructs the audio cable. Also, the RAM sticks slightly block the hard disk. But given my budget, this seemed to be a good choice at Rs 2,080.

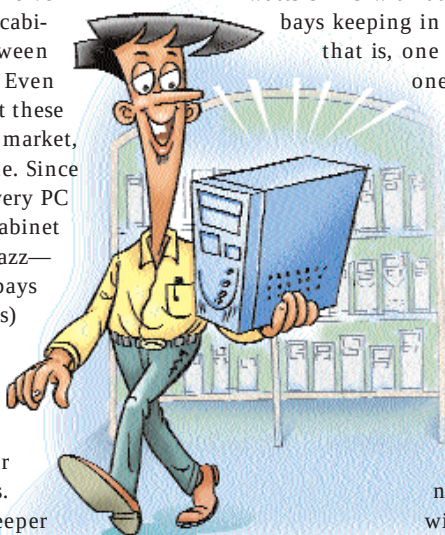


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